



GOODBYE TO WINTER

On the last day of *Maslenitsa*, the Lady Maslenitsa dummy is burned together with any leftover *blinis*. This gesture is a farewell to winter and marks the start of Lent. The day is also called Forgiveness Day because people beg pardon of one another before the 40 days of Lent begin.

A carnival atmosphere during *Maslenitsa* means lots of eating, drinking, and snowball fights in the city's parks.

EASTER CELEBRATIONS

The 40 days of Lent end with *Paskha*, or Easter. In Russian Orthodox churches on Easter Sunday the priest blesses the breakfast meal. This traditionally consists of a sweet cylindrical bread, *kulich*, eaten with a cheese mixture in the form of a pyramid also called *paskha*.



Snow covers the ground for many months of the year so Muscovites are used to dressing for the cold.



PANCAKES GALORE

Stuffed with delicious fillings, pancakes called *blinis* are round, warm, and golden to symbolize the sun. The tradition of eating *blinis* during *Maslenitsa* originated because rich foods were not eaten during Lent. *Blinis* made for *Maslenitsa* provided an opportunity to use up eggs, sugar, milk, and butter before the great fast began.

In fact, *masla* is the Russian word for butter.